Under the Wolf, Under the Dog

By Adam Rapp

(Page 1-3) How to start. Okay. Here it goes. Mrs. Leene said I should begin by describing myself. So, my name is Steve Nugent. I'm just seventeen. It was my birthday last month, in November. Now it's the middle of December, and the trees around here arc caked in ice and sort of silvery in that creepy, wintry way, so right now seventeen seems like a hundred years off.

In terms of size, I'm six foot three and about 145 pounds, which is way too skinny, I know. I can't help that right now. The doctors say I'll fill out in a few years. At this point I would describe myself as being a pretty high-percentage dodge-ball target. I'm also blind in my right eye, which I will tell you more about later.

So I'm currently in residence at this place in the middle of Michigan called Burnstone Grove. There are about thirty-five kids here. About half of us are drug addicts, and the other half have tried to check out of

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this world in one way or another. Probably a third of us have dabbled in both pursuits. I don't entirely fit into either category, so I'm what they call a Gray Grouper. The Red Groupers are the junkies, and the Blue Groupers are the suicide kids. There are only seven Gray Groupers, and we're generally kept here for a month or two before we're either shipped back home or sent to another, more affordable, facility.

The truth is that I could easily be a Red or Blue Grouper. I've done some drugs, and I have to admit that I've through about the other scenario more than once. All of that will come later, though. I don't want to tell you everything just yet.

INTRODUCTION

Steven Nugent was a gifted student, in the honor program at school, taking accelerated classes and he appeared to have the world by the tail . . . that is until his world and his family began to fall apart. This is his story . . . . Under the Wolf, Under the Dog by Adam Rapp

(Page 6) So . . . a couple of months ago, my brother, Welton, hanged himself with a necktie. I think

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that's a good place to begin. My Mom died just a few weeks before that . . . (Page 9) My mom my mom my mom my mom my mom. . .

(page 10-14) Maybe Welton killed himself because he lived in the basement. Who knows what all that damp air and cement will do to a person. Maybe he killed himself because for the last year of his life all he did was smoke weed and play Vice City on his Play Station II. And then again, maybe it was some weird noise in my brother's head, some little digital murmur he never told anyone about. I've heard about that – how you wake up one day and there's like this permanent dial tone droning somewhere in your head, a little Dustbuster trapped where the brain saves you from going crazy. After a while you wind up ending it all just to make things quiet again.

I found Welton in his room in the basement. He'd knotted the necktie around a hook at the top of his door. The hook had broken, but that didn't stop the asphyxiation. What's weird is that he was kneeling. It looked like he was praying or pulling up weeds in a

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garden.

For some reason half his face was blue. Right now when I close my eyes and try and see the parts of his body, I keep missing stuff, like his arms and his shoulders. I can see his face as clear as day and I could even go into detail about his Adam's apple or this little blue vein under his right eye or the weird paste that was coming out of his left nostril, but other more obvious things like limbs are lost to me. Limbs and eye color. I can't place that either. It was like someone had stolen that stuff.

The EMT guys were as quiet as aliens, and when they pushed the gurney through the living room, I finally reached over and closed Welton's mouth.

"Bye," I said to him as they wheeled him away. Just for a second I had the feeling that he might say something back, but he didn't. He just looked sort of waxy and stunned.

I know my mom would have been making coffee for everyone and trying not to cry – she was strong like that – but she was already dead. [I remember her last

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few weeks] . . . I was about to get ready for bed [one night] when I heard my mom call for me. Whenever she would call out my name like that – especially during her last few weeks – it was like getting thumped between the shoulder blades with a hammer.

(Page 47-50) In the hospice room, my mom was trying to reach the straw from her water cup. She was totally bald at this point, and the whites of her eves had dulled to this weird brownish gray. She only weighted eighty-something pounds and her lips had sort of disappeared. My mouth hurts just imagining her.

MOM: Steven, help me drink, honey.

I took a step toward her and I could see a new growth pressing through her forehead. There were things emerging all over her lately. At first they were calling it breast cancer, but now it was everywhere. A few weeks before, the oncologist had discovered a tumor in her abdomen that was the size of a baseball.

She took my hand and asked me to do an Our Father with her. I knelt down at the side of her bed and bowed my head. She took my hands with one of

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hers, and we began. [Our father who art in heaven, hallowed be thy name] Her fingers were bloated and soft. While we prayed, I sort of went blank. I kept waiting for something to stir inside – like a holy fluttering or whatever – but it never came. When we were through praying, my mom fell asleep.

Even though her mouth was all dried and shriveled, she was sort of smiling. The morphine always made her happy. I must confess here that there was a time or two when I was tempted to slip the needle into my own vein just to see what it was like, but that would have been heinous. I slid my hands out from under hers and quietly left her room. (Page 52) All of a sudden, for some reason, my [house] felt like it was shrinking, like the walls were totally losing in on me. So that's when I left. The keys to the Fairmont were on the kitchen table. I grabbed them – no one else would be using them anytime soon.

(Page 55-57) I got bored with the radio after about fifteen minutes and turned it off. The last think I needed was more insanity in my life. Suddenly the

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steering wheel was vibrating. I looked at my hands and they were trembling so bad I thought the veins in my wrists would burst. I pulled over to a Shell station. I was sort of hyperventilating, so I had to take a moment to catch my breath. That's when I started doing the Our Father again. [Our father who art in heaven, hallowed be thy name] I sat there for a moment and thought about my mom. It was her groans of pain that would get me the most. Sometimes they didn't even sound human.

(Page 77-79) When I turned onto our block, I switched the lights off and stopped the engine. Then I shifted to neutral and coasted into the driveway. I left the car keys on the kitchen table and limped straight to my mom's room. She was sleeping really still and her room smelled even worse than ever, I just stood there and watched her curtains blowing for a moment. I remember how blue they were. I think it was the first time I had ever noticed them.

A moment later I heard the door creak behind me. I turned around and my dad was standing in the

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entrance. He was wearing a three-piece suit. It was gray and it looked too small, like he'd stolen it. He made a swallowing sound and adjusted the knot in his tie.. .

DAD: She's dead.

He just stood there staring at my mom, but I wouldn't look at her. You couldn't have paid me a million dollars. I was afraid of what I might see, that some other crazy tumor was popping out of her mouth or something. Then he said it again. "Dead." One word. All by itself.

(Page 90-91) My mom my mom my mom my mom my mom ... The day after she died, they cremated my mom and stuffed her ashes into a pine box and put an eight-by-ten photo next to it. When the priest announced that there would be a moment of silence for those of us, who were too shy to share a special memory or speak on [her] behalf, Welton started singing "The Star Spangled Banner."

(Page 94) Mrs. Leene says that everyone grieves differently, that sorrow and anger manifest themselves in strange ways because of how our minds are actually

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designed to protect us from those feelings. I will say this: I wish I could have cried then. I think if I could have had a good cry, things might have gotten better somehow.

(Page 239-241) [That night, I found that my mom had left Weldon and me a letter]. . . *(Steven reads)* "Remember me, please. An ordinary woman with a good heart. A woman who loved her children and took great pride in them. Remember that I was a great nurse who treated everyone with the same compassion. Remember that I wanted our family to be close, but I died without that happening and I felt sad about it. Remember that I loved you both with my whole heart and though I was far from a perfect mom, I did the best I knew how.

Welton, have faith that your back will heal and that you will one day again play basketball. [aside: (Page 10) As a junior, Welton was the starting forward on the basketball team, but he had to quit three-quarters of the way through the season because of a herniated disk. My brother never quite made it back onto the basketball court]

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Steven Jacob, remember that I loved you – and would have done anything to stay with you. I think you are the smartest person I know, my sweet boy. The Moon will rise, The Sun will set, Please do not forget . . . . Mary Lee Nugent." *(Steven puts his hand to his face and pushes hard against his eyes with his thumbs, struggling to control his emotions)*

(Page 244-250) I woke to a nurse feeding a tube into my right arm. The IV needle was cold, and I couldn't see out of my right eye. Everything on the right side of my body sort of throbbed, and I was afraid to move. "Where am I?"

NURSE: You're in the intensive care unit of the ophthalmology ward at Medical Associates.

"What happened?" My voice sounded like it hasd been taken out and put back in.

NURSE: Well, from what I hear, you put ywn thumb through your right eve. You have a shield over it. It was a various serious puncture, Steven. There's a strong chance that you've lost vision in your right eye.

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(Page 272-273) . . . "My mom died," I said. I had no idea that was going to come out of my mouth, but it did. "She had breast cancer . . . And she died." I could feel this totally thick sort of anguish feeling taking over my body that has never quite left. *(Long silence)*

(Page 6) And then . . . a couple of months ago, my brother, Welton, hanged himself with a necktie. [I found him . . .] (Page 286-288) Down in the basement, Welton's door was three-quarters open. The Price Is Right was on full volume. My brother's room was a cyclone of laundry, CD boxes and warped and ketchup-stained paper plates. His stereo had been turned down, but a CD was spinning quietly. It was that Bottomside song "Forty Holes and Forty Goals." I turned the TV off and the music played. *[Sing a couple of lines of the song here – link to a video of the song is provided at the end of this selection]:* "There's a hole in my head, I'm gonna find it; I'm gonna fill it . . . . There's a hole." I pressed stop and turned the stereo off. I turned around and there he was.

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He'd hanged himself from a coat hook at the top of the door. He'd used one of my dad's old Marine Corps ties. I just stared at him for a moment. "Hey . . . Everything's gonna be okay, okay?" Then I closed his door, which was actually really heavy, and headed back upstairs. *(Long silence)*

(Page 2) So [now] I'm currently in residence at this place in the middle of Michigan called Burnstone Grove.

(Page 310) [Before you go] I just have to say a few more things. I've been thinking about them a lot the past few days. It's sort of this list I'm starting . . .

1. People are born and people die.
2. Parents get cancer and their ashes get stuffed into earns.
3. The urns get buried in holes
4. Brothers break your heard.
5. You have to deal with stuff on your own and that's all there is to it.

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Song "Forty Holes and Forty Goals" by Bottomside :
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=p-8yV4JRehA

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Adam Rapp
ISBN: 978-0763618186
Publisher: Candlewick Press
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2004

AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

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